

Pre Drake Game: UNI's last regular season game of the 2025-2026 season, will they win?

March 1st, 2026, at 2 pm in the Knapp Center in Des Moines, Iowa. UNI Panthers and Drake Bulldogs face off in the last game of the regular season for both teams. UNI is currently standing at 7th in the Missouri Valley Conference (MVC) and has a record of 18-12. Drake is currently standing in 9th place in the MVC with a record of 12-18. Going into this game, Drake is sitting at a 8 game losing streak. Unfortunately for the Bulldogs, last time these teams faced off, the Panthers won 86 to 62. ESPN stats predict that UNI has a 68.3% chance of winning. Looking at team stats, Drake on average scores 76 points a game, while UNI only scores 69.1. On the other hand, Drake, on average, has 75.2 points scored against them. UNI has 61.4 points against them on average. Looking at notable players, Drake has their star shooter Jalen Quinn, who scores 19.8 points per game. He also has the most assists on average, with 3.1. When it comes to rebounds for the Bulldogs, Okku Federiko has the most on average, with 5. UNI's rebound champ is Leon Bond III with an average of 5.1 rebounds a game. The Panthers' top scorer is Trey Campbell with 13.3 points per game and 3.9 assists per game on average. Looking beyond their top performers, Drake seems to only have 1, Quinn. The rest of the Bulldog team's stats seem comparable to those of the bench players for UNI. The Panthers might not have a crazy good scorer, but they do have several good shooters with higher stats than most of Drake's team. Due to this, I predict that the Panthers will bring home a win.

Post Drake Game: Cats sweep Drake for the first time since 2020

On March 1st, 2026, Drake and UNI faced off at the Knapp Center in Des Moines, Iowa. Drake would be fighting to end their 8-game-long losing streak. UNI would be fighting to sweep Drake for the first time since 2020. 4,488 people showed up to cheer on these teams in their last game of the regular season.

The game started with a layup by Will Hornseth, putting the Panthers in the lead by 2. The pattern that quickly emerged was to move the ball across the court and for Drake to attempt 3-point shots. At the start of the game, the Bulldogs kept it close, but with 6 minutes left in the half, UNI began to gain a significant lead. During the first half, UNI's defence was able to keep Drake occupied until the shot clock ran out often. When it didn't run out, UNI held them till they were forced to shoot. This is not that surprising because UNI has one of the best defences in the nation. When the Panthers weren't defending, they were making 2-point shots. This allowed them to have a higher success rate compared to the Bulldogs' lower rate due to them attempting more 3-point shots. The half ended as it started for UNI, Hornseth made a basket. Although this time it was a 3-point shot. Hornseth threw the ball right before time expired. It was a very clean 25-foot turnaround jump shot to close out the half with the Panthers at 39 and the Bulldogs at 24.

The second half saw the continuation of UNI's lead. The half opened with a foul on Drake's Andrew Alia. This allowed the first point of the half to be scored by Tristain Smith during a free throw. UNI ends up with its largest lead of the game during this half. The Panthers were ahead of the Bulldogs by 25 points. The Bulldogs were able to lessen the gap, but it never disappeared. UNI kept ahead of Drake by several points for the entirety of the half. Some notable plays from the second half were when Tristan Smith was able to steal the ball from the Bulldogs and pass it to Leon Bond III, who then took it down the court before passing it back to Smith so he could dunk the ball so hard it rocked the hoop. Another notable play was when Hunter Jacobson scored his first points this season by landing a 3-point shot. This was such an amazing moment, not only because it was the first time he scored, but it was also just a really good shot. The last notable play was the clean 27-foot 3-point shot by Kyle Pock to close out the game for UNI.

The game ended 75-53, UNI sweeping Drake for the first time since 2020. Looking at the after-game stats, UNI leads in field goal percentage at 47%. Duke had a percentage of 31% with a total of 58 shots, where 37 of them were 3-point shots. Coach Jacobson was also interviewed after the game. When asked about what player he thought contributed the most to the game, Jacobson said Leon Bond III, who was just always there when you needed him to be. Jacobson was also asked about his son Hunter. Jacobson said he was proud that he was able to play this season after dealing with several injuries starting in his senior year of high school. Regarding the upcoming MVC Arch Madness tournament, Jacobson would like the team to have an even better defense and get more rebounds. In this game, UNI had 32 rebounds. Overall, Jacobson was happy with the outcome of the game and ready for the tournament.

Note: During the broadcast, the announcers accidentally spread misinformation about someone dying. They were corrected shortly after, but it reminded me that misinformation can come from anywhere.

Outlook for MVC Arch Madness: A hard road ahead

This weekend, teams from the Missouri Valley Conference (MVC) men's basketball will travel to St. Louis to participate in Arch Madness. UNI is one of these teams. UNI will start the weekend by facing off against the Evansville Purple Aces this Thursday, March 5th, at 8:30 pm. This is not going to be a very hard game for UNI. The Panthers have beaten the Aces twice this season. Both games were won with a 14+ point margin. Evansville is also ranked in 11th place in the MVC. UNI is ranked 6th. There is always the chance that UNI could lose, but this seems very unlikely.

Looking forward in the tournament, if UNI wins, they will then face off against the 3rd-ranked team, Illinois State. Illinois State has beaten UNI twice this season. However, both games were very close. Especially the most recent game. That game very well could have been won by UNI, as there was only a 2-point margin. The Panthers were, in fact, predicted to win that game. If UNI plays Friday against Illinois state it will be an extremely close game. The game will also be another late-night game, starting at 8:30 pm

If UNI wins Friday, they will most likely have to face Bradley, the 2nd ranked team. This game will be just as hard as the game on Friday. Luckily for UNI, they have won once against Bradley this season. And that win was the more recent game of the 2, taking place on February 6th. UNI was predicted to win this game. But as we saw with UNI's most recent game against Illinois State, that prediction can be wrong.

If UNI makes it to the Sunday championship game, they will likely be against Belmont, Murray State, or UIC. The Panthers have lost twice to Belmont, but both games were close to the end. UNI has beaten Murray State twice this season. The first game was fairly close, but the second was not at all. UNI won that game with a 29-point lead. UIC has won once against the Panthers. The most recent game was won by UIC 69-61. This game would be another very tough game. UNI was not really favored to win in either of their games against UIC. No matter what, the Panthers have a hard road ahead of them. Their defense will likely play a huge factor in their games; it's just a matter of whether they can score. This tournament will no doubt be fun.